

ROUGH CUT | KAVEREE BAMZAI

Stars Bucked

You need a big man to back a big idea, said Amole Gupte recently at the FICCI-Frames conference. The writer was speaking of his little film, *Taare Zameen Par*, which became big partly thanks to its star. Another huge star, Shah Rukh Khan, spoke of how vital the star system is for the survival of any film industry. It is, but only if the stars work. Enough. And for the right price. Even as we speak, major stars are sitting at home, painting canvases in black, spending time with their equally out-of-work girlfriends while their vanity projects unravel, or doing post production on films connected to one or other member of their family. Stars have to work to be taken seriously. Which may explain why Akshay Kumar, at reduced price please, continues to be such a favourite with directors despite having shown us the limits of karate comedy. Witless and clueless his films may be, stuffed with all manner of low rent Hollywood imports, but at least the man shows up for work. Not everyone can be Dibakar Banerjee and have the courage to make *Love Sex Aur Dhokha* with fresh actors and an even fresher script. Or be Anurag Kashyap and write enough bad dialogue for big bad movies like *Kurbaan*, so he can direct the small good movies he wants to—like the forthcoming *Girl in Yellow Boots*.

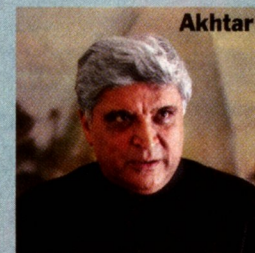
The so-called studios ended up pandering to the star system but in such flagrant ways that they are now sitting on a pile of films they can't release like Eros, hastily reworking budgets like UTV or simply not doing any more work like Indian Films. Movie budgets made at the height of the boom are being lowered but egos take longer to be cut to size. Salman Khan has seen only Rs

5 crore of the reported Rs 20 crore he signed *Veer* for. Shah Rukh's film has made money for him and Karan Johar but not for Fox Star Studios, who nevertheless seem delighted

to have paid so heavily for the privilege. Saif Ali Khan has tried out at least three different hairstyles while waiting for his magnum opus *Agent Vinod* to take off at his projected budget of Rs 60 crore, which no one wants to make for more than Rs 25 crore. Even Akshay has to be content with his film, *Tees Maar Khan*, selling to UTV for Rs 55 crore, which is far less than what Farah Khan's previous blockbuster was picked up for by Eros three years ago, at Rs 74 crore. Perhaps Bollywood stars should take heart from the fact that it has happened to their counterparts in the West too. The days of \$20-million paychecks are long gone. The new stars are either the franchises, where studios ensure they don't allow the actor to become bigger than the superhero or CGI or when they really get lucky, the story, which can turn a \$15,000 *Paranormal Activity* into a \$192-million movie.



NOMINATED: Lyricist Javed Akhtar, Congress leader Mani Shankar Aiyar, educationist Bhalchandra Munekar, actress-dancer B. Jayashree and anthropologist Ram Dayal Munda as members of the Rajya Sabha.



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APPOINTED: Former Supreme Court judge P.V. Reddy as the chairman of the 19th Law Commission. The commission was without a chairman since July 2009, when the term of Justice A.R. Lakshmanan ended.

TEST-FIRED: The vertical launch version of the 290-km-range BrahMos from a warship in the Bay of Bengal off the Orissa coast. With this, India became the first country in the world to have a "manoeuvrable" supersonic cruise missile.

RANKED: Saina Nehwal as the No. 5 badminton player of the world. She is the first Indian woman to break into top five as well as the first to make it to the All-England semi-finals.



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